Activity 1 assessment criteria: DATA COLLECTION assessment due for **14 Oct 2026 (via Google Classroom)**

Please name the title of the document as: Group X - Activity 2 (X is your group number)

One student submitted the assignment on behalf of the group!

Theme 1: The impact of AI/GenAI in small businesses
Theme 2: Factors that influence eco-friendly behaviour at work

- Craft a more specific RQ (5 points):
    - Narrow down the topic (e.g., what level you want to focus on (individual? group? organisational?); what aspect do you want to focus on (impact of AI, the change in organisation, the dark side of using AI by employees, how to promote eco-friendly at work? etc.)
    - Explain why this choice.
    - Follow the PEO/PICOT template.
- Indicate the nature of the data you need to answer this question (2.5 points)
    - Primary data (focus on interviews of managers)
    - Secondary data
- Describe how you will search for these data (2.5 points):
    - Managers' interview design (i.e., whom to interview, which questions to ask, etc.)
    - Existing data search (i.e., keywords, databases, inclusion/exclusion criteria, etc.)
- Collect data and describe the relevant data collected (5 points):
    - Primary: At least two interviews (see table given in course #3) - **FACE-TO-FACE interview incl. recording**
    - Secondary (see table given in course #3)
- Self-assess your work (5 points):
    - What you have learned during the process
    - What would you like to do differently next time
- 4 pages long (APA reference style)
- Appendix (Mandatory) (minus 2 points without Appendix): (at least 6 sources)
    - Data management tables

For Theme 1: suggest the question: How local business owners are using tools like ChatGPT in daily operations? For theme 2: suggest the question: How employee initiation can help to promote eco-friendly behaviour at work? 1

- Do you use any Gen AI-related tools to support your work? If so, describe the process (in detail) and evaluate how much you depend on those tools. Using Gen AI responsibly - declaring your use of AI won't impact your grade. The instructor reserves the right to make final decisions in evaluating the assignment, including giving penalties, or rejecting the assignment.

Topic: The impact of AI/GenAI in small businesses

important sites: FNEGE,

One RQ each till Thursday 10/09

Jeanne

- In what ways does generative AI attract customers in local cafes? (v broad)
- To what extent does generative AI facilitate social media marketing within small businesses (local cafes)?

Dorine

- How does the use of generative AI in marketing of small businesses affect the way customers view them?

Chantal

- How does the introduction of GenAI tools influence the understanding of organizational roles and the culture of innovation in small service-sector businesses?
- How does the informal, employee-driven use of GenAI influence the established culture of collaboration in small agencies?

Yelyzaveta

- How does Generative AI influence employee roles and work organization in small IT businesses?
- How does the use of Generative AI affect task allocation and responsibilities in small IT businesses?

Amelie

- What barriers prevent IT Businesses from using AI and how does this affect their ability to compete with larger firms?
- How are small sport businesses (gyms fex) using AI tools for scheduling and customer engagement and what impact does that have on their growth?

How does the use of generative AI in marketing of small businesses affect the way customers view them?

- maybe select 5 different website/designs types and let people give us their thoughts

- maybe digital business

Literature review:
https://research-ebsco-com.gorgone.univ-toulouse.fr/c/77mckk/viewer/pdf/ux7vyolc75?route=details
Experiental narratives in marketing
This document explores how well generative AI, like ChatGPT, can create product reviews that engage consumers through embodied cognition—making readers feel they can almost experience the product—and affect, or emotional tone.

Key points:
- ChatGPT produced reviews with stronger positive emotions and tones than human experts
- Consumers sometimes rated AI-generated reviews higher in embodied cognition, especially for certain products .
- Despite AI's strengths, consumers noticed issues like hallucinations (inaccurate details) in AI content .

Why it matters: This research helps marketers and AI developers understand the strengths and limits of using AI to create persuasive content. It shows AI can effectively convey positive feelings but needs improvements to avoid factual errors and better mimic human authenticity.

https://research-ebsco-com.gorgone.univ-toulouse.fr/c/77mckk/viewer/pdf/xgggd3q2qb?route=details
Generative AI in marketing and principles of ethical design and deployment
This document explores how Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) is transforming the field of marketing.

Main topic: The document examines how GenAI can enhance or replace human roles in marketing, and proposes ethical guidelines for its use.

Key points:
- GenAI can improve marketing strategies, research, and actions, making processes faster and more efficient .
- The technology can create new products, personalized marketing messages, and even virtual influencers .
- Ethical use of GenAI is crucial, and the document introduces ASSURANCE principles (Autonomy, Security, Sustainability, Representativeness, Accountability, Nonbiasedness, Crediting, Empowerment) to guide its application .

Why it matters: As GenAI rapidly evolves, understanding its impacts and ethical implications is vital for marketers, policymakers, and consumers to ensure beneficial outcomes .

https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0167811624000843?getft_integrator=clarivate&pes=vor&utm_source=clarivate

The power of generative marketing

The article examines whether **generative AI can create marketing images that perform as well as, or better than, human-made images**. (IDEAS/RePEc)

- **AI-generated images were often rated as higher in quality, aesthetics, and creativity** than human-created images.
- In a real-world field study with **173,000+ ad impressions**, AI-generated banner ads achieved **up to 50% higher click-through rates** than professional stock images. (IDEAS/RePEc)
- AI can produce marketing visuals **much faster and at substantially lower cost**, making high-quality visual marketing more accessible.
- The study suggests AI can **complement human creativity**, rather than necessarily replacing human marketers or designers. (MGT Tum)

Main takeaway: Generative AI can create visual marketing content that is not only cheaper and faster to produce, but can also **match or outperform human-made content in consumer response**. (IDEAS/RePEc)

https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0268401225000866?pes=vor&utm_source=clarivate&getft_integrator=clarivate

customer reactions to generative Ai

The article examines how consumers react to **AI-generated vs. real images** in service marketing.

- **Real images generally lead to more positive reactions** because they feel more authentic and trustworthy.
- The negative effect of AI images is stronger for **high-involvement and hedonic services**, such as hotels, holidays, and leisure experiences.
- Consumers may see AI images as **less realistic, reliable, or authentic**, reducing their intention to use or recommend the service.
- For **low-risk, functional services**, AI-generated images may be more acceptable.

Main takeaway: The more customers care about authenticity and accurately imagining an experience, the more important real imagery becomes.

Generative Ai and customer engagement with the retailer

Main topic: The paper tests whether generative-AI chatbots improve customer engagement and purchase intention in online retail—and whether this depends on the product being sold.

4 key points

1. Across four scenario-based experiments, GenAI chatbots increased both customer engagement with the retailer and purchase intention.
2. The key mechanism is **perceived control**: chatbots help customers feel better informed and more able to make a decision, both cognitively and behaviourally.
3. The effect is strongest for **experience goods**—products such as clothing, travel, or beauty items whose quality is difficult to judge before use.
4. For **search goods** with a small, simple range—where attributes are easy to compare—clear structured product descriptions may work better than a chatbot. However, a chatbot becomes useful for search goods when customers face choice overload.

Why it matters for your literature research

This is a highly relevant empirical source for the customer side of your question. It provides evidence that GenAI can improve how customers relate to a retailer, not merely streamline internal marketing work. The pathway is:

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GenAI chatbot → greater perceived control → greater engagement → stronger purchase intention
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For small businesses, it suggests that GenAI may improve customer perceptions when it genuinely helps customers make difficult choices—not simply when it is added as a novelty. Product type and assortment complexity are important conditions to include in your research model.

One limitation: it studies online retail and scenario-based experiments, rather than real small businesses or broader AI-generated marketing content. You could therefore use it to support a focused sub-question on chatbot-enabled customer interaction, while seeking additional studies on authenticity, trust, and AI-generated social-media/advertising content.

Article record and abstract · DOI: 10.1016/j.jbusres.2026.116182

A Systematic Literature Review on the Impact of Generative AI in Digital Marketing

Main topic: This is a systematic review of how generative AI is being used in digital marketing—especially for content creation, personalization, and customer engagement—and the risks that shape responsible adoption.

4 key points

1. GenAI enables faster, lower-cost marketing content: text, images, and multimodal campaigns can be produced and adapted at scale.
2. Personalization is a central benefit. AI-generated messages and campaigns can be tailored to customer segments, potentially improving relevance and engagement.
3. The biggest risks are privacy, bias, misleading content, and legal/regulatory compliance. These risks can directly affect consumer trust.
4. Adoption depends on more than the technology: perceived usefulness, organisational culture, and ethical governance influence whether firms use GenAI successfully. The paper draws on Technology Acceptance Model and Innovation Diffusion Theory.

Why it matters for your literature research

This is a strong **background and framework source**, but not direct evidence on your exact question. It helps you argue that GenAI marketing may improve customers' perceptions through relevance, creativity, and responsiveness—but may harm perceptions if customers see it as inauthentic, intrusive, biased, or deceptive.

For your question, it suggests examining customer perception through outcomes such as:

- perceived authenticity

- trust and privacy concerns
- perceived personalization/relevance
- brand credibility and quality
- disclosure of AI use

A useful refinement could be: *How does small businesses' use and disclosure of generative AI in marketing influence customers' perceived authenticity, trust, and credibility of those businesses?*

The study is a PRISMA-based review of research from 2018–2025, so it is useful for mapping the field and identifying gaps—particularly the need for more empirical work on long-term brand equity and consumer trust.
Full open-access article

The role of generative artificial intelligence (GAI) in customer personalisation (CP) development in SMEs

https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s44244-023-00012-4

Theory : The paper uses the Dynamic Capabilities (DC) theory to explain how SMEs (small-and-medium-sized-enterprises) can adapt, build and reconfigure their digital tools to stay competitive in a changing market.

Key points:

- GAI achieves personalisation through Deep Learning and Smart Data acting as mediators, supported by the Internet of Things (IoT), which acts as a moderator providing real-time customer data
- Successfully implementing this GAI-enabled model allows SMEs to **achieve better interactive marketing, value co-creation with customers and improved customer loyalty**

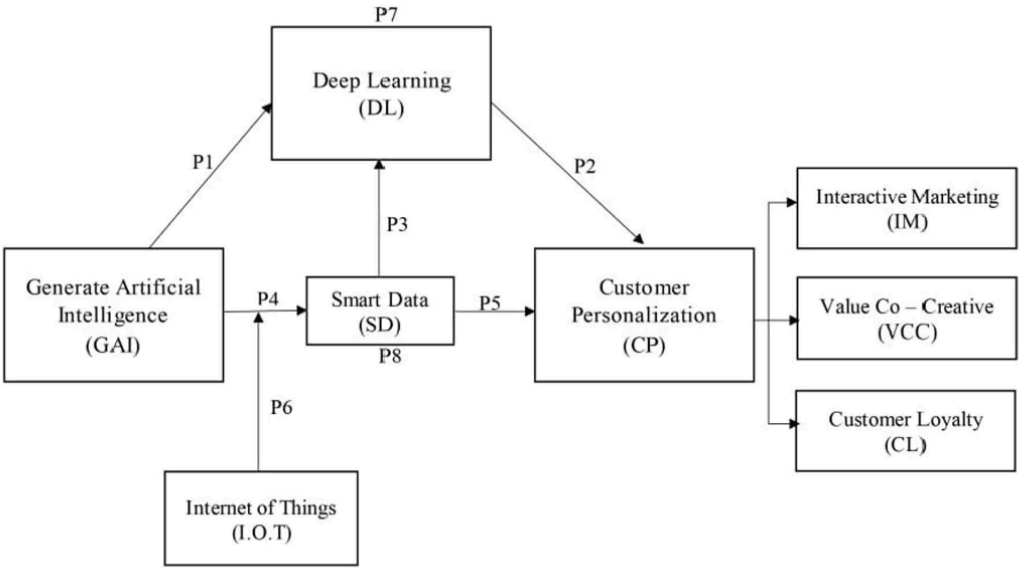


Fig. 1 Theoretical framework of the role of GAI in CP development. Source: Author's own work

Adoption and impact of GAI

https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2667096824000211

Theory: The paper applies 9 behavioral and tech adoption theories (such as TAM, UTAUT, TTF, TOE, TPB, and Diffusion of Innovations) to explain how marketers and consumers adopt GAI tools like ChatGPT to drive business strategy.

Key points:

- GAI achieves **hyper-personalisation and operational efficiency** by processing user data to generate tailored text, ad copy, image assets and dynamic consumer content at scale
- Implementing GAI-enabled workflows allows businesses to **improve interactive marketing, enhance customer engagement, automate real-time support and boost campaign ROI.**
- Successful deployment **requires mitigating challenges** surrounding AI hallucinations, data privacy, training bias, loss of human touch, and workforce skill gaps.

The Impact of Generative AI Images on Consumer Attitudes in Advertising
https://www.mdpi.com/2076-3387/15/10/395

Disclosing AI-generated image or copy? Understanding consumer responses to the AI-generated green advertisements
https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0378720626000881

Possible changes:

- How does the use of generative AI in marketing affect consumers' perceptions of authenticity towards small businesses?
- How does the use of generative AI-generated marketing content influence consumer trust in small businesses?
- How does disclosure of generative AI use in marketing affect consumers' perceptions of small businesses regarding authenticity and trust?
- *(How do customers perceive small businesses that use generative-AI-created marketing content, particularly regarding authenticity and trust?)*
- How do customers perceive generative-AI-created marketing content used by small hospitality businesses, particularly regarding authenticity and trust?

How does disclosure of generative AI use in marketing affect consumers' perceptions of small businesses regarding authenticity and trust?

Dorine:

Experiential narratives in marketing: a comparison of Generative AI and Human Content
https://research-ebsco-com.gorgone.univ-toulouse.fr/c/77mckk/viewer/pdf/ux7vyolc75?route=details

Summary

The paper starts from the idea of experiential marketing, where the goal is not simply to communicate what a product does, but to make consumers imagine what it feels like to experience it. For example, a whisky review might describe its smell, texture, taste, and the emotions associated with drinking it. The authors focus on three characteristics of this type of writing: embodied cognition, meaning references to physical and sensory experience; affect, meaning emotions and positive or negative tone; and lexical diversity, meaning how varied and rich the vocabulary is.

The researchers conduct three studies comparing AI-generated marketing content with human-created content. The first two studies examine whisky reviews generated by ChatGPT 3.5 versus reviews written by human whisky experts. The third examines chocolate-related social-media posts produced by ChatGPT 4 versus posts from human/verified accounts. The researchers combine automated linguistic analysis with evaluations from human participants, allowing them to investigate both the actual characteristics of the texts and how consumers perceive them.

Study 1A finds a clear difference between human and AI writing. Human experts used substantially more language associated with embodied and sensory experience. Their reviews also had considerably greater lexical diversity. For example, human reviewers used a wider range of specific descriptions relating to aging, casks, flavors, and aromas. ChatGPT 3.5, on the other hand, used more positive emotional language and positive tones. In other words, the AI was particularly good at making the product sound pleasant and appealing, but its descriptions were less physically grounded and linguistically varied.

Study 1B produces a more surprising result. When actual consumers read a smaller selection of the reviews, they generally could not reliably distinguish the AI-generated reviews from the human ones. In some cases, they even rated the AI

reviews more highly in areas such as expertise, usefulness, and authenticity. The authors suggest that AI's clear structure and reader-friendly organization may have contributed to this result. However, participants were also able to identify examples of hallucination—for instance, descriptions of whisky flavors that seemed factually or experientially implausible.

Study 2 tests the more advanced ChatGPT 4 in a social-media context. Here, the results are more favorable to AI. For branded posts, participants generally did not perceive significant differences between human-created and AI-generated content. For unbranded posts, ChatGPT 4's content was actually perceived as having greater lexical diversity, embodied cognition, and overall quality. The AI-generated posts also produced levels of intended engagement and purchase intention comparable to—or in some measures associated with stronger responses than—the human content.

The authors therefore argue that generative AI has developed a significant ability to simulate experiential and emotional communication, even though it does not possess physical experiences itself. One particularly interesting finding is that positive emotional language appears to be an area where AI performs very well. However, the study also suggests that sensory grounding and nuanced vocabulary remain important areas where human-generated content can have advantages, particularly in the older ChatGPT 3.5 model.

The paper's broader implication is that AI can be a powerful tool for producing marketing content quickly and cheaply, but this creates an important trust and misinformation problem. If consumers cannot tell whether a review was written by a real customer or generated by AI, companies or individuals could potentially produce large numbers of artificial reviews or misleading experiential claims. The authors therefore highlight the need for ethical guidelines and greater attention to transparency when generative AI is used in marketing.

Key takeaways

- AI is very good at positive emotional communication. ChatGPT-generated content consistently contained more positive emotions and tones than the human content studied.
- Human experts initially produced richer sensory descriptions. Human whisky reviews contained more embodied cognition and substantially greater lexical diversity than ChatGPT 3.5 reviews.
- Consumers often cannot tell AI and human writing apart. In the experiments, participants frequently failed to identify which reviews were AI-generated.
- ChatGPT 4 performs better than ChatGPT 3.5. In the social-media experiment, ChatGPT 4 was perceived as comparable to or better than human content on several dimensions, particularly for unbranded posts.

- Hallucination remains a serious weakness. Participants noticed implausible product descriptions in some AI-generated reviews, showing that persuasive writing can still contain false information.
- Sensory language matters for marketing outcomes. The study suggests that embodied cognition and diverse sensory language can have a stronger relationship with engagement and purchase intentions than simply using positive emotional language.
- The central tension is persuasion vs. authenticity. AI can produce convincing experiential narratives at scale, but the fact that consumers may not recognize them as AI-generated creates ethical concerns, especially for reviews and influencer content.

Customer Reactions to Generative AI vs. Real Images in High-Involvement and Hedonic Services

Reference: Belanche, D., Ibáñez-Sánchez, S., Pau, J., & Matas, S. (2025). Customer reactions to generative AI vs. real images in high-involvement and hedonic services. *International Journal of Information Management*, *85*, 102954. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2025.102954

Research Topic and Question

This study examines how customers react to AI-generated images compared with real photographs when companies use them to promote services. The researchers are particularly interested in whether the effect changes depending on the type of service and the level of customer involvement.

The main research question can be summarized as:

Do customers react differently to services advertised with AI-generated images compared with real images, and does this depend on whether the service is hedonic and/or high-involvement?

This is an important question because generative AI allows companies to create attractive marketing images quickly and at relatively low cost. However, customers may also question whether AI-generated images accurately represent a real service.

Theoretical Background

The study focuses on the importance of authenticity, credibility, and trust in visual marketing.

A real photograph can act as evidence of what a service actually looks like. For example, a real photograph of a hotel room can help a customer understand what they will receive. An AI-generated image may look attractive and realistic, but it does not necessarily represent an actual room or experience.

The researchers therefore suggest that customers may perceive AI-generated images as less credible or less truthful than real photographs.

The study also considers processing fluency, which refers to how easily consumers can understand and process information. If an image creates uncertainty or makes customers question whether it represents reality, it can negatively affect their response to the advertised service.

Key Concepts

Two characteristics of services are particularly important in the study.

Hedonic services are mainly associated with pleasure, enjoyment, emotions, and experiences. Examples include holidays, hotels, restaurants, entertainment, and leisure activities.

High-involvement services are services for which customers have a lot at stake and therefore spend more time and effort making a decision. They may involve considerable financial, emotional, or personal investment.

The researchers expect authenticity to become more important when customers are choosing an experiential service or making a significant decision.

Methodology

The researchers compare customer responses to AI-generated images and real images used to represent services. The study examines how the type of image influences customers' reactions and considers whether these reactions change according to service characteristics and involvement.

The research uses empirical experiments to investigate consumers' responses rather than simply asking whether people generally like AI.

The study therefore looks beyond the appearance of the images and considers the consequences for customers' perceptions and behavioral responses.

Main Findings

The main finding is that customers can react less positively to services represented by AI-generated images than to services represented by real images.

However, the effect is not the same in every situation.

The negative reaction is particularly relevant when the service is:

- Hedonic, meaning that the experience and emotional value of the service are important.
- High-involvement, meaning that customers have more at stake in their decision.

In these situations, customers appear to place greater importance on whether the image feels authentic and accurately represents the service.

The research therefore suggests that simply making an image visually attractive is not enough. Customers also consider whether they can trust the image as a representation of reality.

Why Does This Happen?

A major explanation is perceived credibility.

When customers see a real photograph, they may assume that the place, product, or experience shown actually exists in that form. With an AI-generated image, this assumption becomes weaker.

For example, imagine a customer choosing an expensive hotel for an important holiday. A highly attractive AI-generated picture might create expectations about the hotel's appearance. If customers later realize that the image was generated artificially, they may question whether the hotel can be trusted.

This problem is less important when the customer is making a simple, low-risk decision.

Therefore, the study suggests that the importance of authenticity increases as the customer's involvement and emotional investment increase.

Managerial Implications

The findings provide several lessons for marketers.

First, companies should not choose AI-generated images only because they are cheaper, faster, or easier to produce. They should also consider how customers will interpret the images.

Second, companies selling experiential or high-involvement services should be particularly careful when replacing real photographs with AI-generated images.

Third, marketers should distinguish between images used for creative purposes and images that are expected to represent reality. AI may be useful for creating an atmosphere, illustrating an idea, or developing creative advertising. However, real photographs may be more appropriate when customers need an accurate representation of the actual service.

Finally, companies should consider transparency when using AI-generated content. Customers may react negatively when they feel that an artificial image is being presented as though it were a real representation.

Conclusion

The study shows that generative AI provides useful opportunities for marketing, but its effectiveness depends on the context.

AI-generated images are not necessarily problematic in every type of advertising. However, when customers are purchasing an important or emotionally meaningful experience, authenticity and credibility become particularly important.

The central message of the study is therefore:

The more customers rely on an image to understand and imagine a real service experience, the more important it becomes that the image is perceived as authentic and credible.

For marketers, the choice is not simply between a cheaper AI image and a more expensive photograph. The choice also concerns how much trust and authenticity the image needs to communicate.

Chantal

Zhang, L., & Hur, C. (2025). The impact of generative AI images on consumer attitudes in advertising. *Administrative Sciences, 15*(10), Article 395. https://doi.org/10.3390/admsci15100395

Research Topic and Question

Zhang and Hur (2025) investigate whether consumers respond differently to advertising images made by generative AI rather than humans. They ask: (1) do evaluations differ when the image source is not revealed; (2) how does explicit disclosure that an image is AI-generated affect evaluations; and (3) can the stated reason for using AI reduce negative reactions?

Theoretical Background

The study draws mainly on the Persuasion Knowledge Model (PKM) and authenticity theory. The PKM proposes that consumers become more critical when they recognise a persuasive attempt and begin to question the advertiser's motives. In this case, AI disclosure can make consumers question whether the advertisement is authentic or manipulative. The authors also use the idea of algorithm aversion: consumers may distrust AI-based outputs, especially when they are explicitly identified as AI-generated.

Key Concepts

Generative AI refers to systems that create new content, here advertising images produced with text-to-image models. AI disclosure means informing consumers that the image was generated by AI. The outcome variables are attitude toward the advertisement, preference, trust, and purchase intention. A key moderator is the stated motivation for AI use: cost efficiency, privacy protection, or improving visual appeal.

Methodology

The authors conducted three online experiments with Chinese participants (total $n = 418$). In Study 1 ($n = 130$), participants evaluated AI-generated and human-made advertisements for coffee, medical aesthetics, and a public-service campaign without being told which images were AI-generated. The AI visuals were made with DALL-E 3, Midjourney v6, and DreamUp. Study 2 ($n = 79$) tested source disclosure by telling participants whether an image was AI-generated or human-made. Study 3 ($n = 209$) disclosed AI use in commercial advertising but varied the reason given for using it. Participants rated the advertisements on seven-point scales for trust, attitude, preference, and purchase intention.

Main Findings

When the source was not disclosed, consumers evaluated AI-generated and human-made images similarly; none of the observed differences was statistically significant. Once AI use was disclosed, consumers had significantly more favourable attitudes toward human-made images. The effect of disclosure depended on the explanation provided. A privacy-protection rationale produced evaluations comparable to human-made images. A visual-appeal rationale produced slightly lower but non-significant evaluations. In contrast, a cost-efficiency rationale significantly lowered trust and purchase intention and slightly reduced attitudes.

Why Does This Happen?

Disclosure provides information that consumers use to infer the business's motives. According to the authors, knowing that AI was used activates persuasion knowledge and algorithm aversion, making consumers more cautious about authenticity and possible manipulation. Cost-focused disclosure may signal that the company prioritises savings over quality or sincerity. Privacy protection, however, frames AI as benefiting or protecting consumers, which reduces suspicion and makes the business appear more responsible.

Managerial Implications

Businesses should not treat AI disclosure as a simple technical label. If disclosure is required or voluntarily offered, it should explain a consumer-centred and ethical reason for using AI. Privacy, safety, or accessibility may be more credible rationales than saving money. For small businesses especially, transparent communication should show that AI supports the customer experience rather than replaces care, creativity, or quality.

Conclusion

This article is highly relevant to research on small-business authenticity and trust. It shows that disclosure of generative AI use can change consumer perceptions even when the image itself is comparable to human-made content. Most importantly, the meaning consumers attach to the business's reason for using AI determines whether disclosure harms or preserves trust. The study does not specifically examine small businesses or directly measure authenticity, so an interview study can extend it by exploring how consumers define "authentic" AI use and which disclosure messages they consider trustworthy.

Li, J., Geng, L., & Chang, Y. (2026). Disclosing AI-generated image or copy? Understanding consumer responses to the AI-generated green advertisements. *Information & Management, 63*(5), 104388. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.im.2026.104388. Article record

Research Topic and Question

Li, Geng, and Chang (2026) examine how brands should disclose generative AI use in green advertising. Specifically, the article asks whether consumers respond differently when a brand discloses that AI created the green image rather than the green copy (text) in an associative green advertisement. Associative green advertisements create an environmentally friendly impression but offer relatively vague claims rather than concrete evidence of environmental performance.

Theoretical Background

The study is grounded in signaling theory, which explains how consumers use observable cues to judge information they cannot easily verify. In green advertising, consumers may be skeptical of vague environmental claims and suspect greenwashing. The authors argue that the type of AI disclosure acts as a signal: disclosing AI-generated imagery versus AI-generated copy leads consumers to infer different things about the specificity and credibility of the brand's environmental claim.

Key Concepts

AI disclosure is a label that tells consumers which advertising element was generated by AI. Environmental claim specificity is the extent to which consumers perceive a green claim as concrete, clear, and verifiable. Brand authenticity refers to whether consumers see the brand as genuine and sincere. Mental simulation describes whether consumers imagine the process of creating the advertisement or focus only on its finished outcome.

Methodology

The authors conducted three experiments with a total of 632 participants. Study 1 tested whether disclosing AI-generated green imagery rather than AI-generated green copy affected brand attitudes and intentions to buy the advertised green product. Study 2 examined the psychological mechanism behind this effect: perceived environmental-claim specificity followed by brand authenticity. Study 3 tested whether mental simulation of advertisement creation changed the effect. The studies therefore test both the effect of disclosure type, why it occurs, and when it is most likely to occur.

Main Findings

Disclosing that the green image was AI-generated, rather than disclosing that the green copy was AI-generated, increased consumers' attitudes toward the brand and their purchase intentions for the green product. This is important because the study does not find that AI disclosure is inherently harmful. Instead, consumer reactions depend on which part of the advertisement is identified as AI-generated.

The effect occurred because AI-image disclosure increased perceived environmental-claim specificity, which then increased perceived brand authenticity. In other words, consumers considered the environmental message more concrete and the brand more genuine when AI was disclosed as the source of the image rather than the written green claim.

Why Does This Happen?

When consumers imagine the process of making the advertisement, they may assume that generating an appropriate green image with AI requires detailed instructions, research, and deliberate choices. This makes the environmental claim appear more specific and credible. In contrast, if consumers learn that the green copy was AI-generated, they may infer that the environmental wording itself was automatically produced and less carefully grounded in real environmental action. The effect disappears when consumers focus only on the final advertisement rather than the process by which it was created.

Managerial Implications

Brands using AI in associative green advertising should disclose AI involvement carefully. Where appropriate, identifying the green image—not the environmental copy—as AI-generated may preserve or improve brand attitudes and purchase intention. More broadly, green claims should remain specific, evidence-based, and connected to genuine environmental practices. AI disclosure cannot replace sustainability evidence, but it can influence whether consumers see the message as authentic rather than as greenwashing.

Conclusion

This article is relevant to research on AI disclosure, authenticity, and trust because it shows that consumers react not only to whether a business uses AI, but also to what AI is used to create. For small businesses, the findings suggest that disclosure should explain AI's role without making environmental or brand claims appear automated, vague, or insincere. Your interviews could explore whether consumers make similar distinctions outside green advertising: for example, whether AI-generated visuals seem more acceptable than AI-generated brand messages, product descriptions, or claims of authenticity.

Hartmann, J., Exner, Y., & Domdey, S. (2025). *The power of generative marketing: Can generative AI create superhuman visual marketing content? International Journal of Research in Marketing, 42*(1), 13–31. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijresmar.2024.09.002

ONLY FOR BASICS, would be best to use alongside Zhang and Hur

Research Topic and Question

Hartmann, Exner, and Domdey (2025) investigate whether generative AI can create visual marketing content that equals or exceeds human-made content in marketing performance. Their central question is whether AI-generated images can outperform human-created images in quality, realism, aesthetics, creativity, consumer attitudes, and real advertising outcomes, while being cheaper and faster to produce.

Theoretical Background

The article is positioned within research on generative marketing and the changing economics of creative production. It starts from the idea that text-to-image AI can generate large volumes of photorealistic visual content at very low cost, potentially augmenting human creativity and changing how firms create advertisements. Rather than testing one main psychological theory, the study provides a systematic empirical comparison between AI-generated and human-made marketing imagery across multiple marketing contexts.

Key Concepts

Generative AI refers to text-to-image models that generate new visuals from written prompts. Visual marketing content includes advertising images, social-media visuals, banner advertisements, and product-related imagery. Marketing effectiveness is assessed through perceived image quality, realism, aesthetics, creativity, attitude toward the advertisement, following a creative brief, click-through rate, and production cost.

Methodology

The research consists of three studies. In Study 1, the authors used 2,400 real-world human-made marketing images as input and prompted seven text-to-image models—including DALL-E 3, Midjourney v6, Firefly 2, Imagen 2, Imagine, Stable Diffusion XL Turbo, and Realistic Vision—to produce 10,320 synthetic images. These visuals received 254,400 human evaluations.

In Study 2, AI models and commissioned human freelancers received identical creative briefs. A between-subjects study with 1,575 Prolific participants assessed ten outcomes, including perceived creativity, attitude toward the advertisement, behavioural intention, and how well each image followed the brief. Study 3 was a real-world field experiment involving more than 173,000 advertising impressions, comparing AI-generated banner ads with professional human-made stock photography.

Main Findings

AI-generated marketing imagery could outperform human-made imagery in perceived quality, realism, and aesthetics. In the creative-brief comparison, the strongest AI model, DALL-E 3,

outperformed human freelancers on five marketing metrics and received directionally higher ratings on the other five. Participants also perceived its advertisements as more creative.

The field study showed that AI-generated banner ads could compete with professional stock photography and achieved click-through rates up to 50% higher than the human-made comparison image. AI production was also substantially less expensive: the budget required for one freelancer-made image could create approximately 2,500 DALL-E 3 images.

Why Does This Happen?

The study suggests that AI can produce polished, visually appealing images at scale and generate many alternatives for a single creative task. This makes it more likely that firms can identify a visual that fits a campaign objective well. The results show that consumers can evaluate AI imagery positively when judging the finished visual, especially when the image is not explicitly discussed as AI-generated. However, the paper tests comparative performance rather than directly measuring psychological explanations such as trust, authenticity, or reactions to disclosure.

Managerial Implications

Businesses can use generative AI to create and test many marketing-image variations rapidly and at far lower cost than traditional production. This may be especially valuable for smaller firms with limited advertising budgets. Managers should still use human oversight to ensure that AI visuals follow the creative brief, fit the brand identity, and avoid misleading, biased, or low-quality outputs. The article also highlights the need for firms and policymakers to consider transparency and ethical issues as AI images become harder to distinguish from human-made visuals.

Conclusion

This article provides strong evidence that AI-generated visual marketing content can be commercially effective and, in some circumstances, outperform human-made alternatives. It is useful for explaining why small businesses may adopt generative AI: it offers lower costs, speed, scalability, and potentially strong ad performance. However, it does not directly investigate disclosure, authenticity, trust, or small businesses. For your research, it is best used as background on the practical benefits of AI marketing images, alongside research that specifically examines how disclosure affects consumer perceptions.

Nuremberg Institute for Market Decisions. (n.d.). *Transparency without trust: The impact of consumer skepticism of AI-generated marketing content*. https://www.nim.org/en/publications/detail/transparency-without-trust

Research Topic and Question

This Nuremberg Institute for Market Decisions (NIM) research examines how consumers react when marketing content is labeled as AI-generated. It asks whether transparency labels improve trust or instead create skepticism, reduce engagement, and weaken consumer responses to advertising. It also examines whether these

effects differ according to consumers' existing trust in AI, beliefs about human creativity, and the type of product advertised.

Theoretical Background

The publication addresses a transparency dilemma in AI marketing. AI labels are intended to help consumers make informed decisions and support trustworthy marketing, especially under upcoming EU labeling requirements. However, transparency does not automatically create trust. The research argues that a label can make consumers more aware of possible artificiality, manipulation, or lack of authenticity without resolving their underlying concerns about AI.

Key Concepts

AI disclosure refers to labeling marketing content as "AI-generated." Consumer skepticism is a cautious or negative reaction to the credibility, naturalness, or authenticity of AI-produced content. Engagement includes willingness to click, research, or buy the advertised product. Trust in AI is consumers' general confidence in AI technology and companies using it. The research also considers beliefs that creativity is uniquely human and whether a product is innovative/high-tech or traditional.

Methodology

NIM conducted controlled online experiments and a representative survey of 1,000 respondents each in the United States, the United Kingdom, and Germany. The survey measured knowledge of AI in marketing and general trust in AI. Experiment I showed participants identical product advertising, but one group was told the visual was a photograph and the other that it was AI-generated. Participants evaluated appeal, credibility, emotional impact, memorability, and willingness to learn more.

Experiment II involved German participants only. Two groups viewed the same six advertisements for established and innovative products. The only difference was the label: one group saw "AI-generated" and the other "human-generated." Participants rated usefulness, clarity, appeal, and their willingness to research or purchase the product.

Main Findings

Trust in AI was low: only around one fifth of respondents trusted AI itself or companies' promises about AI. When an identical advertisement was labeled as AI-generated, consumers evaluated it more negatively and were less willing to engage with the advertised product. The negative response was especially strong for emotional aspects such as credibility and emotional impact.

The second experiment confirmed that an AI label made advertisements appear less natural and less useful, leading to more negative attitudes and lower willingness to research or buy. However, consumers with greater trust in AI were more open to AI-generated advertising. Negative reactions were also stronger among people who

believed creativity belongs exclusively to humans. AI-generated advertisements were more accepted for innovative and high-tech products than for traditional products.

Why Does This Happen?

The AI label changes the meaning consumers attach to otherwise identical content. Instead of judging only the advertisement's visual quality, they may question its authenticity, emotional sincerity, and the business's motives. The label can activate a "trust penalty": consumers become wary of content created by a machine, particularly when they already distrust AI or associate creativity with humans. For innovative products, AI appears to fit the product category more naturally, reducing this mismatch.

Managerial Implications

Businesses should recognise that compliance with AI-labeling rules is necessary but not sufficient to build trust. They should explain how AI supports quality, relevance, or human creativity rather than simply adding a label. AI-generated content may be more appropriate for innovative, technology-related products, while traditional products may benefit from stronger human involvement or a combination of human and AI creativity. Firms should also build familiarity and trust over time by being transparent, responsible, and consistent in their AI use.

Conclusion

The research shows that transparency without pre-existing trust can lead to skepticism rather than confidence. This is highly relevant to research on how AI disclosure affects perceptions of small businesses: disclosure may cause consumers to question a business's authenticity and trustworthiness even when the content itself is unchanged. Your interviews could investigate what explanations, signals of human involvement, or types of products make AI use feel more acceptable and authentic in a small-business context.

JEANNE

1. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/385249345_The_AI-authorship_effect_Understanding_authenticity_moral_disgust_and_consumer_responses_to_AI-generated_marketing_communications

The AI-authorship effect: Understanding authenticity, moral disgust, and consumer responses to AI-generated marketing communications

Colleen P. Kirk [a], Julian Givi [b]

SUMMARY (GEMINI)

1. *The AI-Authorship Effect* (Kirk & Givi, 2025 / *Journal of Business Research*)

- **The Mechanism ("Moral Disgust"):** When consumers discover that marketing communications were generated by AI rather than a human, they view the content as inauthentic. This perceived inauthenticity creates a sense of "moral disgust" or betrayal, which in turn reduces customer loyalty and positive word-of-mouth (PWOM).
- **Emotional vs. Factual Content:**
    - **Emotional Messages:** Using AI to express feelings (e.g., gratitude, empathy, inspiration, or personal stories) severe brand authenticity and trust. Consumers feel fake warmth or deceptive intimacy.
    - **Factual Messages:** The negative effect disappears when AI is used for straightforward, functional, or informative content (e.g., product specifications, transactional updates).
- **Human-in-the-Loop & Ownership:** Disclosing that AI was used merely to *edit* or *refine* human-written content eliminates the negative hit to trust and authenticity. Conversely, attempting to hide AI generation or pretending an AI text was written by a human incurs severe penalties when discovered.

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2. https://d1wqtxts1xzle7.cloudfront.net/124802603/the_impact_of_aigenerated_advertising_and_virtual_influencers_on_consumer_perception_and_brand_authenticity_1_-libre.pdf?1759163147=&response-content-disposition=inline%3B+filename%3DThe_Impact_of_AI_Generated_Advertising_a.pdf&Expires=1790505043&Signature=BRqeeBRa5XVCIohS3UQ2wmsK6dum-vBIK7ilqB16X9wNQmPcEnU6sOY4zHKwYBqYveSQeDAU-c7wNjBh2i2tRyz~OBqM5jwDAfNgWaaBf9j0aoxeC7qOYu48oYBroM6YGi6lNM~QDiSjBFNtuClcp5Gju9oWTH4WU3NO8XWOqaqNqalqB7KMkxAl~1OEFMiGgojd2ZizUnNcE3ly4oajQEqbqxaMjWsEyZYrRxWzZB2nX9-U2B~a2itqO9asUr4GuOv7ucrl1eXE1tmpJ9U3lpHNYezyoBa2zOwcR-qKbLvloYbTcS1LgwuHDJqjVmMKeNEmg17KnkrCdGYdq0~Skw__&Key-Pair-Id=APKAJLOHF5GGSLRBV4ZA

The Impact of AI-Generated Advertising and Virtual Influencers on Consumer Perception and Brand Authenticity

SUMMARY (GEMINI)

The Expectation of Human Touch: Small businesses often build their competitive advantage around human relationships, community connection, and personal passion. Because consumers expect authentic human involvement from local or small brands, disclosing pure AI

generation in emotional or brand-story communications damages small businesses more severely than larger corporations (where automated operations are already expected). Efficiency vs. Connection: While customers tolerate AI for functional assistance (e.g., automated scheduling, product descriptions), outsourcing the "soul" of a small business's story or customer appreciation to AI leads consumers to view the business as lazy, deceitful, or impersonal.

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3. file:///C:/Users/madel/Downloads/MRU-IE_2025(2)_6.pdf

https://ojs.mruni.eu/ojs/intellectual-economics/article/view/9114

One step forward, two steps back: AI generated content vs. perceived trust, authenticity and credibility

SUMMARY (GEMINI)

The Paradox of Trust, Authenticity, and Credibility **(Majerova et al., 2026 /** ***Intellectual Economics*****)**

- **"One Step Forward, Two Steps Back":** While small businesses use generative AI to optimize efficiency, disclosing or recognizing AI-generated content creates a net-negative effect on perceived trust, authenticity, and credibility.
- **Content Framing Matters:** Similar to Kirk & Givi's findings, rational/informational content authored with AI maintains acceptable levels of credibility and trust. However, emotional or value-driven messaging created by AI drastically reduces subjective brand value.
- **Demographics & Medium:** The study found no significant variation across age groups—distrust toward AI-generated emotional marketing appears consistent across generations.

Unstructured interview- Questions

To customers

- When you browse a small business's social media or website, do you assume the content was created by a human employee/owner? How would you feel if you learned it wasn't?

"need for ethical guidelines and greater attention to transparency" (A1)

- If a small business includes a label stating *"This image/caption was generated using AI,"* what is your immediate first impression of that business?
- Would you perceive that label as enough transparency? If not, what would you expect the organisation to do?

"simply making an image visually attractive is not enough. Customers also consider whether they can trust the image as a representation of reality." (A2)

- Does knowing AI was used make you doubt whether the business's products or services are as high-quality as advertised? Why/ why not?

" consumers had significantly more favourable attitudes toward human-made images" (A3)

- why? what makes you lean forward human- made labels?

"The main finding is that customers can react less positively to services represented by AI-generated images than to services represented by real images." (A2)

- do you feel like the knowledge that AI was used changed the use/taste/… of the sold product? if yes, how?

To marketers

"choice is not simply between a cheaper AI image and a more expensive photograph. The choice also concerns how much trust and authenticity the image needs to communicate." (A2)

- What is your experience with using generative AI for Marketing? For what did you use it for?
- Do you think the ads (or whatever) display your service honestly?
- Did customers ever feedback smth if you used generative AI?

Literature review: Chantal, Jeanne, Dorine - Sunday, 27/09
Questions: Amelie, Lisa - Tuesday, 29/09
Interview: Sunday, 03/10